

Waiting for the culture-shock crash you keep hearing is coming

7 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

Culture shock doesn't run to a schedule, so your good first few weeks aren't a debt coming due. Homesickness tends to ease as the weeks pass, though **how fast varies a lot**.

THE GOAL

You're reading a bad day here as a bad day, not the start of a crash. Say in one plain sentence what actually happened today, a mistake, a tired evening, an argument.

CHECKLIST

A day here goes wrong, or you feel unexpectedly tired, low, or irritable, and the first thought is "here it comes."

- ☐ Say "here it comes" out loud or in your head the moment it shows up, before acting on it.
- ☐ Say in one plain sentence what actually happened today (a mistake, a tired evening, an argument), not "the crash."
- ☐ If today traces to one clear thing, do the thing that fixes it now: send it, say it, close it.
- ☐ Write one line noting what happened and what you did about it, dated, somewhere you'll see it again.
- ☐ If nothing set it off, do one ordinary thing that usually helps, like a walk or food, before reading more into it.
- ☐ Jot down that today felt off too, wherever you're keeping track of these days, even with no clear reason.
- ☐ Name one thing from the last few good weeks that's still true today, like your routine or a person you've met.
- ☐ Message or see one person actually near you tonight. If you're tempted to call home instead, do the local one first.
- ☐ Answer the thought "here it comes" out loud or in writing: "this is a rough day, not evidence of anything."
- ☐ Pick one ordinary thing already on your plan for tomorrow that has nothing to do with today's dip.
- ☐ If this low feeling has followed you for several days running and the ordinary things haven't helped, tell one person today.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Don't make people back home your main outlet on a hard day here.
- 2 If you're avoiding people here, read that as the cost of homesickness landing on local ties, not a verdict on your friendships back home.
- 3 Feeling a bit homesick tends to ease on its own as the weeks pass, though how much varies a lot person to person.

What actually shapes a hard stretch is who's around you

DO

Most of the people interviewed pointed to the **ties they built with people around them**, not people back home, as what actually helped.

Most interviewees named supportive ties with people around them, locals or fellow students, as what shaped their adjustment. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't make people back home your main outlet on a hard day here.

People who leaned that way, or who coped by avoiding the problem or blaming themselves, paid a real cost in rockier stress patterns overall. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

If you're avoiding people here, read that as the cost of homesickness landing on local ties, not a verdict on your friendships back home.

Homesickness's damage landed specifically on relationships with people in the new place, not on relationships with people from home. [Source 4](#)

The schedule you're bracing for doesn't exist

KNOW

Your good weeks don't obligate you to a hard stretch later.

Tested across decades, that exact shape never once turned into a **timeline that fits anyone's real experience**. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

You don't need a downward turn before your adjustment counts as real.

For their overall adjustment specifically, nobody in the group picked the graph showing a decline, only flat or rising ones. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Arriving somewhere new rarely hits like a shock or a high, and for most people it barely registers.

In a study of exchange students across many countries, most people's stress barely shifted on arrival, in either direction. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Feeling a bit homesick tends to ease on its own as the weeks pass, though how much varies a lot person to person.

On average, homesickness faded only a little across a full term, and how much it faded varied a lot by student. [Source 4](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

There's a rough timeline for this, like everyone hits a hard patch around the same point, roughly three months in.

ACTUALLY

How much this varies between people is exactly why no single point in time can predict your case. A pattern that fits one person can say **nothing about the next**. [Source 1](#)

Sources

1. https://www.nafsa.org/sites/default/files/ektron/files/underscore/theory_connections_adjustment.pdf
2. https://eprints.ncl.ac.uk/file_store/production/290946/8BFB8790-D5EF-492F-B5EC-52292501D23F.pdf
3. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4507515/>
4. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC5280212/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Moving somewhere new at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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